PMDD — Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder

A severe form of PMS that significantly impacts your emotional and physical health — and is very treatable

❓ WHAT IS PMDD?

PMDD is a severe, chronic medical condition affecting **3–8% of women** during their reproductive years. Symptoms occur in the **luteal phase** (1–2 weeks before your period) and resolve within days of menstruation starting.

- 🔬 PMDD is a **recognized medical disorder** (DSM-5, ICD-11) — not "just mood swings"
- 🧠 Caused by an abnormal neurological response to normal hormonal fluctuations
- 📅 Symptoms must occur most menstrual cycles for ≥1 year to diagnose
- 🚫 NOT caused by depression alone (though depression may worsen it)

💡 **PMDD is cyclical — tracking your symptoms on a calendar/app helps confirm the diagnosis**

🚨 RECOGNIZING PMDD SYMPTOMS

😔 Emotional (≥1 required)

Severe depression · Hopelessness
Anxiety or tension · Rage
Mood swings · Irritability
Feeling "out of control"
Difficulty concentrating

😰 Physical

Breast tenderness/swelling
Bloating and weight gain
Headaches and migraines
Joint or muscle pain
Fatigue · Food cravings
Hypersomnia or insomnia

Diagnosis requires at least 5 symptoms, with ≥1 being emotional/mood-related, confirmed over 2+ cycles

💊 TREATMENT OPTIONS

First-Line Medical Treatments

- ⭐ First-Line **SSRIs** (fluoxetine/Sarafem, sertraline, paroxetine) — can be continuous OR luteal phase only
- Effective **SNRIs** (venlafaxine) — alternative to SSRIs
- Rx **Combined OCP** (esp. drospirenone-containing, like Yaz) — FDA-approved for PMDD
- Rx **GnRH Agonists** (Lupron) — for severe, refractory cases; temporary menopause
- Rx **Alprazolam** — anti-anxiety, luteal phase only (short-term)

Non-Medication Approaches

- 🧘 Stress reduction: yoga, meditation, mindfulness
- 🏃 Regular aerobic exercise — improves serotonin
- 🥗 Diet: reduce salt, sugar, caffeine, alcohol premenstrually
- 💊 Supplements: calcium 1200mg/day, Vitamin B6, magnesium
- 🛏️ Consistent sleep schedule

📋 TRACKING YOUR CYCLE — KEY TO TREATMENT

Track symptoms daily for at least 2 months. This helps confirm PMDD and guides treatment decisions.

- 📱 Apps: Flo, Clue, Ovia — track mood, pain, and energy
- 📓 Daily symptom diary — rate symptoms 1–10 each day
- 📅 Note first day of period and symptom start/stop dates

🚨 Seek Immediate Help If:

- ⚡ **Thoughts of self-harm or suicide — call 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline)**
- Symptoms significantly impact work, relationships, or daily function
- You feel like you can't manage symptoms on your own

PMDD Is Real — and Very Treatable

PMDD is not a weakness or character flaw — it is a neurobiological condition that responds well to treatment. Many women experience dramatic improvement with the right medication and lifestyle support. You deserve to feel like yourself *every* week of the month. We're here to help you find what works. 💕 — (281) 557-0300